PROPOSALS

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Proposal 1:

Strengthening Student-Faculty Engagement for First-Year Integration and Proactive Welfare

1.1 Aim

This proposal seeks to bridge the critical interpersonal gap between first-year students and faculty members by institutionalizing structured avenues for communication, empathy, and informal mentorship. By introducing a formal Faculty Sensitization Module and decentralized Post Mid Semester Student-Faculty Mixers, we aim to dismantle the perceived hierarchical barriers between students and professors. This initiative will shift the campus ecosystem from a reactive welfare model to a proactive one, equipping our faculty to act as informed first responders to student distress while fostering a more approachable academic environment.

1.2 Overview and Current Scenario

The transition from a highly structured school environment to the rigorous, hyper-competitive academic landscape of IIT Kharagpur is one of the most vulnerable phases in a student's life. Currently, the interaction between first-year students and faculty is almost entirely confined to large capacity lecture halls. This pedagogical distance creates a systemic barrier. Students often view professors strictly as evaluators rather than approachable mentors, leading to a profound hesitation in seeking help for either academic or personal struggles. There is currently no standardized mechanism to ensure every freshman establishes a meaningful connection with their departmental faculty early in their academic journey.

Furthermore, while our faculty members possess immense academic and research expertise, they are not formally trained to identify the subtle, non-academic indicators of student distress, such as imposter syndrome, severe burnout or social isolation. As a result, by the time a student's struggle reaches the counselling centre, the issue has often escalated to a crisis level.

1.3 Groundwork and Justification

The rationale for this proposal is grounded in primary observations of the first-year student experience and consultations with the student welfare apparatus.

- Discussions with members of the Counselling Centre indicate that early, informal faculty intervention is one of the most effective deterrents to academic anxiety. Students who feel seen by their professors are statistically more likely to seek help before their academic performance severely deteriorates.

- The period immediately following the first mid-semester examinations was found to be a critical inflection point. This is when freshers experienced their first major academic shock, making it the most strategic time to introduce supportive faculty interaction.
- A survey was conducted to gauge the viewpoints of professors and faculty regarding the matter of student mental health issues and the dynamic of student professor interaction. The results found a high need for the professors to be trained in identifying student distress signals and in how to deal with them.
- Peer institutes, notably IIT Delhi, have successfully implemented structured student-teacher interaction dinners that have measurably improved departmental camaraderie.

1.4 Implementation

To ensure seamless integration into the institute's existing framework, the proposal will be executed through two parallel, carefully sequenced initiatives:

1.4.1 Faculty Sensitization and Integration Module

A structured sensitization module will be incorporated into the broader administrative framework, designed to equip professors with the psychological toolkit necessary to support a diverse student body.

- **Target Audience:** The module will be a mandatory component of the onboarding process for all newly recruited faculty members while being offered as a highly recommended, continuing education seminar for existing faculty advisors.
- **Curriculum and Core Content:** Conducted by well-known counsellors and psychologists of India. The curriculum will be divided into four actionable pillars:
    - Educating faculty on how their classroom demeanor, evaluation feedback, and informal remarks disproportionately impact first-year confidence. This module will address unintentional micro-inequities and emphasize how a professor's perceived approachability directly dictates a student's academic resilience and willingness to seek help.
    - Training faculty to identify the subtle, non-academic indicators of distress. This involves recognizing behavioral patterns such as sudden spikes in absenteeism, erratic drops in academic performance, extreme social withdrawal, or physical signs of severe burnout and sleep deprivation.
    - Providing clear, actionable protocols for how to initiate contact with a struggling student. Professors will be trained in non-intrusive inquiry, active listening and navigating sensitive disclosures (e.g., severe mental health crises, harassment, or financial distress) without crossing professional boundaries or inadvertently escalating the student's anxiety.

- Ensuring faculty understand the exact limits of their pastoral role and know precisely how to seamlessly connect a student with professional counselors at the Counseling Centre or the Hall administration. The focus will be on facilitating a "warm handoff" rather than a cold redirection, maintaining the student's trust throughout the process.
- Incorporating structured mentorship practices for research supervisors, focusing on setting clear expectations, maintaining regular and transparent communication, ensuring fair authorship and workload distribution, and fostering a supportive, non-exploitative guide scholar relationship.

1.4.2 Post-Mid-Semester Student-Faculty Mixers

To humanize the academic experience, structured but informal dinners will be organized at the departmental level.

- These dinners will be mandated to take place in the two-week window immediately following the autumn semester mid-semester examinations, providing emotional and academic reassurance during a period of high vulnerability.
- Logistical Framework and Venue Allocation: Execution will be tailored to departmental scale. Departments with smaller cohorts or sufficient spatial infrastructure will host these mixers internally to foster a sense of departmental familiarity. Conversely, high-intake departments will utilize centralized, high-capacity institutional venues such as the Technology Club or the Kazi Nazrul Community Centre to comfortably accommodate the student-faculty volume.
- A critical challenge of these mixers is the inherent professor-to-student ratio, which often averages 1:50. Unstructured mingling in such environments can quickly devolve into awkward isolation for quieter students. To solve this, the mixers will feature curated, highly scalable engagement events.

  Events:

  1. Beyond the Podium Narratives (Focus: Humanization & Empathy)

  - Concept: Before the dinner begins, 2–3 faculty members are invited to share a brief, 5-minute anecdote about their own undergraduate days, specifically focusing on a time they faced academic failure, struggled with a concept or felt overwhelmed.
  - Utility: This is a highly scalable, one-to-many approach that instantly dismantles impostor syndrome. Hearing an esteemed professor admit they once failed a mid-semester exam or struggled with homesickness humanizes them immediately, making students far more likely to approach them later.

2. Mythbusters: Departmental Edition (Focus: Academic Anxiety)

- Concept**:** A rapid-fire, interactive session moderated by a senior student (e.g., a Departmental Society member). The moderator presents common rumors or anxieties first-year students hold (e.g., *You need a 9.5 CGPA to get a core research internship* or *Approaching a professor during office hours is only for top rankers*). Faculty members then hold up Fact or Myth placards and briefly explain why.
- Utility**:** It directly addresses the invisible stressors and academic misinformation that plague first-year students, using a lighthearted format that easily accommodates an audience of 50+ students per professor.

3. Collaborative Campus Trivia (Focus: Natural Ice-Breaking)

- Concept**:** Students are divided into larger groups of 15–20, and one faculty member is assigned to each group not as a competitor but as the Team Advisor or Lifeline. The Departmental Society hosts a short, 15-minute trivia game focusing on IIT Kharagpur history, campus lingo , and lighthearted departmental trivia.
- Utility**:** Shared goals are the easiest way to break the ice. Placing the professor on the same team as the students forces natural, low-stakes collaboration and gives them a shared topic of conversation to carry over into the dinner.

1.5 Impact

- Sensitization of faculty behavior towards students: By having the faculty realize the impacts that their behavior may have, it enforces them to have self-regulation on the things they say and their overall nature.
- Establishment of a Proactive Safety Net: By training faculty to recognize early signs of distress, the institute will shift the burden of initiating help-seeking behavior away from the overwhelmed student, significantly reducing the number of academic and psychological crisis cases.
- Dismantling Hierarchical Anxiety: Informal interactions post-mid-semester will humanize faculty in the eyes of freshers. This comfort translates directly into increased classroom participation, higher attendance in faculty office hours and a stronger inclination to pursue early undergraduate research.
- Enhanced Departmental Cohesion: Standardizing these interactions ensures that every student, regardless of their department's size, feels a sense of belonging and academic camaraderie from their very first semester, laying the foundation for a cohesive, supportive campus culture.

Proposal 2:

Upgrading the Setu App into a Unified Ecosystem for Opportunity Discovery and Transparent Communication

2.1 Aim

This proposal seeks to resolve the prevailing information asymmetry at Indian Institute of Technology, Kharagpur by upgrading the official Setu app into a centralized, dynamic and searchable portal. By introducing a dedicated Opportunities Hub and a Student Representative Communication Desk, we aim to streamline the distribution of academic, professional and institutional information. This will ensure that every student has equitable, real-time access to research roles, competitions and representative updates, thereby eliminating the reliance on fragmented communication channels.

2.2 Overview and Current Scenario

At IIT Kharagpur, the sheer volume of academic, extracurricular, and professional opportunities is immense, yet the distribution mechanism remains highly fragmented. Currently, crucial information regarding scholarships, hackathons and campus events is disseminated through a chaotic mix of Public Relations' Chairperson emails, ERP notice boards, departmental WhatsApp groups, and external social media pages.

This decentralized approach creates several systemic inefficiencies:

- Students suffer from email fatigue, causing high value opportunities such as corporate case challenges or pre-placement competitions, to be buried in cluttered inboxes.
- This lacks a structured posting mechanism, restricting visibility, often limiting opportunities to a small subset of highly connected students rather than the most qualified candidates.
- Updates from student office bearers (Vice President, Public Relations' Chairperson, Editors, General Secretaries) are distributed across separate platforms. This makes it incredibly difficult for the student body to track policy changes, welfare updates or general championship schedules, leading to a disconnect between the representatives and the residents.
- Niche opportunities, such as women-specific leadership programs or highly specific scholarships, lack a dedicated spotlight, reducing their overall utilization rate.

2.3 Groundwork and Justification

- To ensure the practical viability of this proposal, I held an in-depth consultation with the project managers of the Setu app, Mr. Anindya Roy and Mr. Soham Banerjee. Our discussions confirmed that the extension of these services is highly feasible from a developmental standpoint, as the current architecture of the application is scalable enough to handle them.
- An analysis of digital infrastructure at peer institutes underscores the necessity and impact of this upgrade. For instance, IIT Bombay's official student platform, InstiApp (managed by their Developers' Community, DevCom), successfully integrates a comprehensive campus feed, placement blogs, an institute calendar and a centralized club exploration portal. This proven model demonstrates that a unified digital dashboard drastically reduces information asymmetry and increases student participation in both internal governance and competitive external events.
- Primary feedback collected from various student cohorts at IIT Kharagpur validates the urgent need for a centralized system. Students consistently report a pervasive "fear of missing out" on critical deadlines due to email fatigue. High-value opportunities, such as corporate case challenges, often get buried in cluttered inboxes, while research intern recruitment heavily relies on informal, closed-loop networks (like specific WhatsApp groups). This feedback confirms that the current fragmented distribution mechanism restricts equitable access to opportunities.

2.4 Implementation

The integration will be executed through the development of two primary modules within the Setu app ecosystem:

2.4.1.1 The Centralized Opportunities Hub

This section will serve as a constantly updated, well-categorized repository of student opportunities, featuring sorting filters, deadline countdowns and direct application links.

- A secure portal where faculty members and lab heads can formally post openings for research interns, project assistants or lab positions. Students can view prerequisites and apply directly through the app, democratizing access to academic mentorship.
- Seamless integration of all opportunities currently circulated via PRC emails.
- A dedicated calendar and notice board for internal events, including General Championship (GC) fixtures, Inter-IIT selections, Open IIT events and departmental society competitions, complete with rulebooks and registration links.

- A curated feed for reputed corporate hackathons, innovation challenges, and case competitions (e.g., those linked to pre-placement offers), ensuring students do not miss high-value external exposure.
- A specialized subsection highlighting scholarships, research fellowships, and leadership initiatives exclusively aimed at empowering women students on campus.
- A continuously updated repository of institutional, alumni-funded, and government scholarships, detailing eligibility criteria, required documentation and application windows.

2.4.1.2 Student Representative Communication Desk

To foster transparency and convenience, this module will consolidate all official communications from student representatives. Our planned channels include:

- A verified feed where the Vice President, PR Chairpersons, Editors and General Secretaries can post official updates, MoMs (Minutes of Meetings) and policy changes.
- Communications will be tagged by portfolio (e.g., Welfare, Maintenance, Sports, Technology), allowing students to easily search for past notices or updates relevant to their specific concerns.
- Implementation of priority-based push notifications for urgent updates, ensuring critical welfare or administrative news reaches the student body instantly, bypassing the delays of traditional email servers.

2.4.2 Development and Technical Integration (The Builders)

- The software development will be spearheaded by the Setu app's core technical and support team, overseen by project owner and managers Mr. Soham Banerjee and Mr. Anindya Roy. They will be responsible for building the front-end UI/UX for the 'Opportunities' and 'Communication' modules.
- For backend stability, server scaling, and secure ERP API integrations (such as role-based authentication using Institute IDs), the Setu team will work in direct collaboration with the Computer & Informatics Centre (CIC).

2.4.3 Operational Workflow and Content Management (The Moderators)

- The flow of information must be managed. The Public Relations Chairperson, alongside drafting mass emails, will also act as the central figure for the Opportunities Hub. They will verify the credibility of external corporate links and standardize the format of event descriptions.

- To populate the research portal, the Dean of Students' Affairs (DoSA) will be requested to issue an advisory circular to all Heads of Departments. This will formally encourage professors and lab heads to utilize the Setu portal as their primary avenue for recruiting undergraduate project assistants, standardizing a previously informal process.

2.5 Impact

- Centralizing research and internship postings will dismantle the reliance on informal networks, ensuring that opportunities are accessible to all students based on merit and interest, rather than connections.
- By streamlining communication into a single app, we will significantly reduce email clutter and the administrative bandwidth currently wasted on redundant cross-platform posting by student representatives.
- A unified communication desk will bridge the gap between the Technology Students' Gymkhana and the student body, fostering a more informed, engaged and cohesive campus community.
- Providing structured, easy access to corporate challenges and hackathons will directly boost IIT Kharagpur’s representation in national competitions, enhancing students' professional profiles and pre-placement prospects.

Proposal 3:

Establishment of well-being monitoring committee

3.1 Aim

The proposed **Well-Being Monitoring Committee** is intended to serve as a formal accountability and coordination mechanism for student welfare at IIT Kharagpur. Its primary purpose is not to take over the functioning of existing bodies but to ensure that every welfare-related office, cell and initiative on campus carries out its responsibilities with clarity, consistency, and responsiveness.

At present, student welfare on campus is supported through multiple channels, including the Counseling Centre, the SETU platform and student-facing wellness initiatives. These are important assets, but their effectiveness depends not only on their existence but also on whether they are timely, visible, coordinated and answerable to student needs. The committee is therefore proposed to fill the gap between service availability and service accountability.

The long-term objective is to build a welfare ecosystem in which:

- Support systems are reviewed regularly.
- responsibilities are clearly assigned,
- Follow-ups are not dropped.
- gaps are identified before they become crises.
- and students know that welfare is not treated as an ad hoc concern but as an institutional priority.

The committee will strengthen student welfare by ensuring that existing bodies function in a more coordinated and accountable manner, while preserving their independent operational roles. It will not subsume student welfare groups under itself; rather, it will act as a review and coordination layer so that each body remains autonomous in execution but answerable in performance.

3.2 Overview and Current Scenario

IIT Kharagpur already has welfare support structures in place. The institute has a separate counseling center for mental health support, provides 24x7 confidential online counseling through YourDOST, and has also introduced SETU, which includes a well-being and counseling interface as well as grievance-related functions. Student-led support bodies such as the Student Welfare Group and the Institute Wellness Group also exist and are active under the broader

students' welfare ecosystem, but they function as separate student initiatives rather than as formal administrative oversight bodies.

Even with these structures in place, the practical experience of students often depends on how well the system is coordinated. The present challenge is not simply the absence of welfare provisions but the absence of a sufficiently strong monitoring and responsibility framework around them.

The current scenario can be understood through a few recurring issues:

- First, welfare functions remain somewhat distributed across separate bodies, which can lead to gaps in communication and follow-up. A student may approach one channel, only to be redirected elsewhere, or may not receive a timely response because responsibility is not clearly tracked.
- Second, there is often limited visibility of the full welfare ecosystem. Students may know that some support exists but may not know which body handles what, when to escalate a concern or how to check whether an issue has been resolved.
- Third, the system tends to become reactive rather than preventive. Problems are addressed after they are reported, but there is often insufficient structured review to identify recurring patterns, service delays or points of failure.
- Fourth, there is usually a weak feedback loop. Welfare bodies may perform valuable work, but without periodic institutional review, there is limited scope for tracking whether that work is reaching the intended students effectively.
- Fifth, there is a risk of responsibility dilution. In any system with multiple support bodies, a problem can persist simply because no one body is clearly accountable for end-to-end follow-up.

A Well-Being Monitoring Committee is needed precisely because welfare work cannot be measured only by intent or existence. It must also be measured by follow-through, accessibility and institutional accountability. The committee would therefore not be an extra layer of bureaucracy, it would be a mechanism to ensure that the existing system actually delivers what it is meant to deliver.

3.3 Groundwork

- Reviewed alignment with University Grants Commission (UGC) guidelines to ensure the proposal fits within existing institutional welfare frameworks.
- Conducted discussions with key stakeholders including the current General Secretary Students' Welfare, the Counselling Centre and the Dean of Students' Wellbeing to assess feasibility and existing gaps.

- Consulted with ex-officio members of the Gymkhana Council to understand administrative integration and ensure smooth coordination with existing student governance structures.

3.4 Implementation

3.4.1 Nature and Mandate of the Committee

The Well-Being Monitoring Committee should be constituted as a review-and-accountability body, not as an operational replacement for welfare services. Its role would be to:

- monitor whether existing welfare bodies are functioning responsibly,
- ensure timely follow-up of student welfare concerns,
- review overlaps, gaps and delays,
- and create a structured forum where welfare bodies report, respond and improve.

It should not interfere with the internal autonomy of bodies such as the Counselling Centre, SETU, SWG, IWG or hall-level welfare structures. Rather, it should ensure that each of these bodies remains answerable for the responsibilities it has taken upon itself.

3.4.2 Composition

The committee should be small enough to function effectively, but broad enough to represent the major stakeholders in welfare delivery.

The proposed composition is:

- **Chairs:** Dean of Student Affairs and Dean of Student Well-Being
- **Co-chair / Convener:** General Secretaries Students' Welfare, Technology Students' Gymkhana
- **Member from the Counseling Centre:** A senior counselor or designated counselling representative
- **Vice President**, Technology Students' Gymkhana
- **Undergraduate Representative**
- **Postgraduate Representative**
- **Research Scholar Representative**
- **Institute Women's Representative**
- **Member from student welfare bodies:** One representative each from SWG and IWG, in their capacity as separate consultative stakeholders
- **Hall representative from each hall:** General Secretary of Welfare or any other hall representative from ach hall

This structure ensures that the committee has both administrative weight and student legitimacy. It also ensures that the committee includes the people who actually know how the system functions, rather than making decisions in isolation.

3.4.3 Roles within the Committee

Each member should have a defined role.

The Chair should provide institutional authority, approve review outcomes, and ensure that recommendations are not left without follow-up.

The convener should coordinate meetings, compile the agenda, track pending issues and ensure that decisions are translated into action points.

The counselling center representative should report on operational patterns, common student concerns, service bottlenecks, and any systemic needs that require administrative support.

SWG and IWG representatives should bring forward student-level observations, recurring welfare concerns and feedback from their own activities while remaining independent in their internal functioning.

Hall representatives should bring ground-level feedback from residents, since many welfare concerns first appear at the hall level.

3.4.4 Workflow

The committee should work through a simple but disciplined cycle.

First, each welfare body should submit a brief periodic report on its work. This report should not be burdensome, but it should include the following:

- number and type of cases handled,
- unresolved issues,
- common concerns,
- follow-up status,
- and any support required from other offices.

Second, the committee should meet at a fixed interval, ideally once every month or once every six weeks during the pilot phase. The meeting should focus on:

- pending concerns,
- recurring patterns,
- inter-body coordination,

- service bottlenecks,
- and student feedback.

Third, the committee should record decisions in a tracker that clearly distinguishes between:

- cases resolved,
- cases under follow-up,
- cases requiring escalation,
- and recommendations for policy or process change.

3.4.5 Reporting and Accountability

The committee should not function on verbal assurance alone. It should maintain:

- a simple dashboard of broad welfare indicators,
- a review tracker of issues raised and resolved,
- anonymized summaries of recurring concerns,
- and a short periodic report for institutional review.

The dashboard should remain anonymous and aggregate-level only. It should not expose personal student information. Its purpose is to identify patterns, not individuals.

3.4.6 Escalation Mechanism

A clear escalation pathway should be built into the model.

If a welfare issue is unresolved at the level of the concerned body, it should move to the committee for review. If the committee finds that the matter requires administrative intervention, it should be escalated to the Dean's office or the appropriate authority.

This is essential because many welfare failures occur not because no one saw the issue, but because no one had a formal mechanism to move it forward.

3.4.7 Student Feedback

Student feedback should be collected through:

- periodic anonymous forms,
- hall-level inputs,
- feedback after welfare interactions where appropriate,
- and a structured reporting channel through SETU or another official interface.

The committee should not treat feedback as symbolic. Each feedback cycle should lead to one of three outcomes:

- direct action,
- referral to the relevant body,
- or a policy/process recommendation.

3.4.8 Phased Rollout

The committee should begin with a pilot.

In the first phase, the committee may be constituted with a limited core group: administration, General Secretary Students' Welfare, Counselling Center, SETU and a small number of student representatives. This phase should be used to define reporting formats, meeting cadence and escalation rules.

In the second phase, hall representation and broader student welfare stakeholders can be added and a more detailed review tracker can be introduced.

In the third phase, the committee should move into full institutional review mode with periodic reports, thematic reviews and coordinated interventions.

This phased implementation makes the proposal realistic and reduces the risk of over-formalization at the start.

3.5 Impact

If implemented properly, the Well-Being Monitoring Committee would create a meaningful improvement in the way student welfare is governed at IIT Kharagpur.

- Its first impact would be better coordination. Welfare bodies would no longer work in isolation, they would operate within a structured review framework where responsibility is visible and follow-up is tracked.

- Its second impact would be improved responsiveness. Student concerns would move through a clearer channel, reducing the chances of issues being delayed or forgotten.

- Its third impact would be stronger accountability. Welfare bodies would continue to function independently, but their performance would be periodically reviewed, which creates discipline without unnecessary interference.

- Its fourth impact would be better visibility of welfare services. Students would have a clearer understanding of where to go, what each body does and how to escalate a concern.

- Its fifth impact would be more informed policymaking. With anonymized summaries and regular review, the Institute would be better positioned to identify recurring issues and design practical responses.

- Its sixth impact would be reduced duplication of effort. Bodies doing similar work would be encouraged to coordinate, rather than operate separately on overlapping themes.

- Its seventh impact would be greater student trust. A system that visibly monitors itself sends a strong message that welfare is taken seriously and that concerns will not disappear into administrative silence.

In the long run, the committee would help turn student welfare from a set of separate support functions into a more responsible institutional ecosystem, one where help is not only available, but visible, coordinated and answerable.